South Island self-drive: Christchurch to Queenstown, 6-14 March 2027

2027-03-06 → 2027-03-14 · 9 days · 2 travellers · Total 2109 km · longest day 5 h 38

Everything checked fits. 13 details still need confirming (see Open items).

Date	Route	km	Driving	Sunset	Overnight
Day 1 · Sat 6 Mar	Land in Christchurch, sunset over the Port Hills	47	1 h 02	20:09	Novotel Christchurch Airport
Day 2 · Sun 7 Mar	Over Arthur's Pass to the West Coast	314	4 h 26	20:13	Hotel or motel in Hokitika (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)
Day 3 · Mon 8 Mar	Glacier Country: Franz Josef and Lake Matheson	181	2 h 43	20:15	Motel or lodge in Fox Glacier (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)
Day 4 · Tue 9 Mar	Haast Pass to Wanaka	272	3 h 36	20:18	Hotel or apartment in Wanaka (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)
Day 5 · Wed 10 Mar	Lindis Pass and Aoraki/Mount Cook	329	4 h 29	20:10	Peppers Bluewater Resort or Mantra Lake Tekapo
Day 6 · Thu 11 Mar	Mt John, then down to Queenstown	279	4 h 21	20:16	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside
Day 7 · Fri 12 Mar	Milford Road day (no boat)	409	5 h 38	20:19	Motel or hotel in Te Anau (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)
Day 8 · Sat 13 Mar	Takahe in Te Anau, Glenorchy Road	268	3 h 40	20:13	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside
Day 9 · Sun 14 Mar	Return the car and fly	9	13 min	20:11	—

Day by day

Day 1 · Sat 6 Mar · Land in Christchurch, sunset over the Port Hills

depart 15:45 · 47 km · Driving 1 h 02 · Sunset 20:09 · Overnight Novotel Christchurch Airport

The route: over Arthur's Pass to the West Coast glaciers, through the Haast Pass to Wanaka, across the Lindis Pass to Aoraki/Mount Cook and Lake Tekapo, then Queenstown, with a Milford Road day from Te Anau. It covers mountains, lakes, glaciers and wildlife (kiwi, kea, penguins, takahe) with no boats, beaches or walks over 2 hours. All driving ends at least 1 h 45 before sunset; the longest day is about 410 km. 4 of 8 nights are Accor (the most that fits without giving up a sightseeing day; see open items). Today: your flight lands at 14:30. Allow about 75 minutes for immigration, biosecurity, bags and the rental desk, so the car moves at about 15:45. One lookout, then an early night.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
15:45 depart	Christchurch Airport		
16:22–17:22	Port Hills Summit Road lookout (Sign of the Kiwi)	26 km 34 min	Summit Road on the Port Hills: views over Christchurch, the Canterbury Plains and the Southern Alps to the west, and Lyttelton Harbour to the east. Free roadside lookout.
17:53	Novotel Christchurch Airport	21 km 28 min	

Tips

• Declare any food, hiking boots or outdoor gear at biosecurity; clean boots speed this up.

• The rental car should come with a full tank; check before you leave the airport.

• International Antarctic Centre is a 5-minute walk from the terminal but closes at 16:30, so it only fits if you are through arrivals very quickly.

Day 2 · Sun 7 Mar · Over Arthur's Pass to the West Coast

depart 07:30 · 314 km · Driving 4 h 26 · Sunset 20:13 · Overnight Hotel or motel in Hokitika (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)

The big crossing of the Southern Alps on SH73: limestone boulders, an alpine waterfall, the Otira Viaduct and a turquoise gorge, ending with kiwi in Hokitika. About 315 km for one driver, so take every stop as a break.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
07:30 depart	Novotel Christchurch Airport		
08:58–09:43	Castle Hill / Kura Tawhiti	93 km 1 h 20	Kura Tawhiti / Castle Hill: short loop among giant limestone boulders, about 30-45 minutes.
10:32–12:02	Devils Punchbowl Falls track, Arthur's Pass	53 km 45 min	Arthur's Pass village. Devils Punchbowl Falls walk: about 1 hour return on a steep track with 400+ steps (DOC). Kea (alpine parrots) are often around the village; don't feed them. Lunch in the village.
12:09–12:24	Otira Viaduct Lookout	6 km 6 min	Otira Viaduct Lookout: the road snaking down the gorge below the pass.
13:46–14:46	National Kiwi Centre	94 km 1 h 15	National Kiwi Centre: kiwi, tuatara and giant eels. Open 9:00-17:00, last entry 16:30. Adult NZ$43. Eel feeding 10:00, 12:00 and 15:00 with kiwi feeding straight after. No booking needed.
15:19–16:04	Hokitika Gorge	34 km 30 min	Hokitika Gorge: short walk and swing bridge over milky turquoise water. About 30-45 minutes. It's a 33 km side trip inland.
16:37	Hokitika	34 km 30 min	

Tips

- SH73 is steep and winding around Arthur's Pass and Otira. One driver: stop at least every 2 hours.
- Fill up in Christchurch; fuel is limited until the coast. Refuel in Hokitika tonight.
- Hokitika Wildfoods Festival is on Sat 13 March 2027, after you have left, so it won't affect rooms on 7 March.
- Lunch: buy food in Arthur's Pass village (small; café hours not checked), or bring a packed lunch from Christchurch.

Day 3 · Mon 8 Mar · Glacier Country: Franz Josef and Lake Matheson

depart 08:30 · 181 km · Driving 2 h 43 · Sunset 20:15 · Overnight Motel or lodge in Fox Glacier (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)

A shorter driving day so you have time at the glaciers. The free walk now only reaches a viewing point, so if the weather is clear, consider a helicopter landing or heli-hike from Franz Josef: it is the only way onto the ice.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
08:30 depart	Hokitika		
10:31–11:31	Franz Josef Glacier viewing walk car park	138 km 1 h 50	Franz Josef Glacier / Ka Roimata o Hine Hukatere viewing walk: about 30 minutes return. River damage blocks access further up the valley, so obey barriers and DOC alerts. Sentinel Rock (about 20 minutes return) is nearby for a higher view.
11:37–12:52	West Coast Wildlife Centre	4 km 6 min	West Coast Wildlife Centre: live kiwi (South Island's largest kiwi hatchery), tuatara and little blue penguins; penguin feeding usually 11:00 and 15:00. Open 8:30-19:00 daily. The heliport is a 2-minute walk away.
13:27–15:27	Lake Matheson	28 km 32 min	Lake Matheson: the mirror lake with Aoraki/Mount Cook and Mount Tasman reflected on still days. Easy loop of roughly 1.5 hours; calm late afternoon or early morning gives the best reflection.
15:44	Fox Glacier (Weheka) township	12 km 15 min	

Tips

• Optional: helicopter snow landing or heli-hike from Franz Josef (weather-dependent, often cancelled in rain or cloud). Book a flexible fare if you want one, and keep the morning open for it.

• Glacier Country gets heavy rain. On a wet day, swap the order and spend longer at the Wildlife Centre.

• Stop order checked: visiting the Wildlife Centre before the glacier walk saves only 3 minutes, so do whichever suits the weather.

Day 4 · Tue 9 Mar · Haast Pass to Wanaka

depart 08:00 · 272 km · Driving 3 h 36 · Sunset 20:18 · Overnight Hotel or apartment in Wanaka (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)

South along the coast to Knights Point, then up through the Haast Pass waterfalls to the Blue Pools and down past Lakes Wanaka and Hawea.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
08:00 depart	Fox Glacier (Weheka) township		
09:25–09:40	Knights Point lookout	100 km 1 h 18	Knights Point lookout over the Tasman coast (look only, no beach access needed).
10:05–10:25	Haast township	28 km 22 min	Haast: refuel and buy lunch. Fuel and shop hours not verified; fill up anyway, it's the last reliable fuel for about 140 km.
11:05–11:20	Thunder Creek Falls	50 km 37 min	Thunder Creek Falls: a 28 m waterfall a few minutes from the road.
11:25–11:40	Fantail Falls	6 km 4 min	Fantail Falls: short walk to a fan-shaped waterfall.
11:52–12:52	Blue Pools walk	14 km 11 min	Blue Pools walk: rainforest track to swing bridges over clear blue pools, about 1 hour return.
13:51–15:21	Mount Iron Track car park	70 km 54 min	Mount Iron: climb to a summit lookout over Wanaka, Lake Wanaka and the Clutha valley. Allow about 1-1.5 hours return (time not verified against DOC; turn back if it runs long).
15:28–15:48	That Wanaka Tree	3 km 6 min	That Wanaka Tree: the famous willow growing in the lake, a short walk along the Roys Bay lakefront. Photo stop only.
15:52	Wanaka	2 km 4 min	

Tips

• SH6 between Makarora and Hawea was closed by slips from late August 2026 and fully reopened on 23 October 2026, with a 50 km/h limit at Waterfall Slip and traffic lights at Windy Point. Expect short delays.

• Check NZTA Journey Planner for SH6 the evening before. If Haast Pass is closed, use Plan B (see open items).

Day 5 · Wed 10 Mar · Lindis Pass and Aoraki/Mount Cook

depart 07:45 · 329 km · Driving 4 h 29 · Sunset 20:10 · Overnight Peppers Bluewater Resort or Mantra Lake Tekapo

Early start over the Lindis Pass into the Mackenzie Basin, then the best mountain day of the trip: Hooker Valley and the Tasman Glacier, ending at Lake Tekapo.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
07:45 depart	Wanaka		
08:54–09:09	Lindis Pass summit lookout	80 km 1 h 03	Lindis Pass summit: tussock-covered pass, quick photo stop.
10:18–10:33	Peters Lookout, Lake Pukaki	83 km 1 h 03	Peters Lookout: Lake Pukaki with Aoraki/Mount Cook at the end of the lake.
11:14–13:14	Hooker Valley Track (White Horse Hill car park)	45 km 37 min	Hooker Valley Track: walk to the second swing bridge and back (about 1.5 hours return; 45 min each way, DOC). The full track to Hooker Lake is about 3 hours return, longer than your 2-hour limit, so turn back at the second bridge unless you feel fresh. Paid parking: NZ$2.50 per half hour, card only.
13:30–14:15	Tasman Glacier View car park	10 km 15 min	Tasman Glacier View: short steep climb to a view of the terminal lake and the Tasman Glacier.
15:53–16:23	Church of the Good Shepherd	110 km 1 h 29	Church of the Good Shepherd on the Lake Tekapo shore, best in evening light.
16:25	Lake Tekapo	1 km 2 min	

Tips

• No fuel in Mount Cook Village is assumed; fill up in Wanaka or Twizel.

• Tekapo is in the Aoraki Mackenzie International Dark Sky Reserve: on a clear night, step outside after 21:30. A guided stargazing tour must be booked (Dark Sky Project).

• Lunch: bring a picnic from Wanaka; food options at Mount Cook Village were not checked. Dinner in Tekapo.

Day 6 · Thu 11 Mar · Mt John, then down to Queenstown

depart 08:00 · 279 km · Driving 4 h 21 · Sunset 20:16 · Overnight Novotel Queenstown Lakeside

Morning view over Lake Tekapo from Mt John, then back over the Lindis to Central Otago, the Kawarau Gorge and gold-rush Arrowtown.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
08:00 depart	Lake Tekapo		
08:28–09:28	Mt John summit (Astro Cafe)	10 km 26 min	Mt John summit: 360-degree views over Lake Tekapo and the Mackenzie Basin, with the Astro Cafe. Road access hours and any road fee not verified.
11:32–11:47	Lindis Pass summit lookout	125 km 1 h 53	Lindis Pass again, southbound.
12:52–13:37	Cromwell	77 km 59 min	Lunch and fuel in Cromwell (town, many options).
13:51–14:01	Roaring Meg lookout, Kawarau Gorge	15 km 12 min	Roaring Meg lookout in the Kawarau Gorge.
14:31–15:46	Arrowtown	32 km 28 min	Arrowtown: historic gold-mining main street and Chinese settlement.
16:12	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside	20 km 23 min	

Tips

• Optional evening: Skyline gondola up Bob's Peak for the view over Lake Wakatipu (walk from the hotel; check hours).

• Mt John: if the summit road is closed or charged, the lakefront below gives a similar view.

Day 7 · Fri 12 Mar · Milford Road day (no boat)

depart 07:45 · 409 km · Driving 5 h 38 · Sunset 20:19 · Overnight Motel or hotel in Te Anau (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)

The longest day: to Te Anau, then the Milford Road through the Eglinton Valley and the Homer Tunnel to Milford Sound, and back to Te Anau. You see the fiord from the shore. No cruise, since one of you gets seasick.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
07:45 depart	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside		
09:26–09:41	Mossburn (rest stop)	113 km 1 h 32	Rest stop in Mossburn (toilets, stretch).
10:31–10:51	Te Anau	58 km 46 min	Te Anau: fill the tank and buy lunch. Treat this as the last fuel before Milford; fuel hours not verified.
11:40–11:55	Mirror Lakes	57 km 44 min	Mirror Lakes: boardwalk, mountains reflected on calm mornings.
12:32–12:47	Homer Tunnel (east portal)	43 km 34 min	Homer Tunnel: wait at the lights; kea are common here, don't feed them.
12:57–13:17	The Chasm	8 km 9 min	The Chasm: short forest walk to water-carved rock.
13:31–14:31	Milford Sound (Piopiotahi) foreshore	10 km 13 min	Milford Sound / Piopiotahi from the shore: Mitre Peak across the water from the foreshore walk near the terminal. Picnic lunch.
16:21	Te Anau	118 km 1 h 40	

Tips

- One driver and about 410 km on mountain roads: stop every hour or so; the stops above double as breaks.
- Phone signal is mostly absent beyond Te Anau Downs; download offline maps.
- If the Milford Road is closed on the 12th, use Plan C: swap with tomorrow (see open items).

Day 8 · Sat 13 Mar · Takahe in Te Anau, Glenorchy Road

depart 08:30 · 268 km · Driving 3 h 40 · Sunset 20:13 · Overnight Novotel Queenstown Lakeside

Rare takahe at the Te Anau bird sanctuary, back to Queenstown, then the lakeside road to Glenorchy and its mountain views.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
08:30 depart	Te Anau		
08:34–09:19	Punanga Manu o Te Anau bird sanctuary	3 km 4 min	Punanga Manu o Te Anau bird sanctuary: takahe and other native birds by the lake. Free entry. Hours not verified.
10:10–10:25	Mossburn (rest stop)	59 km 46 min	Rest stop in Mossburn.
12:28–12:43	Bennetts Bluff lookout, Glenorchy Road	137 km 1 h 52	Bennetts Bluff lookout over Lake Wakatipu toward the mountains.
13:04–14:04	Glenorchy	22 km 19 min	Glenorchy: village at the head of Lake Wakatipu, mountain views and short lagoon walkway.
14:47	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside	46 km 39 min	

Tips

- Refuel in Queenstown this evening so the car goes back full (check your rental's fuel policy).
- Pack tonight; tomorrow is car return and flight only.
- Lunch in Glenorchy or back in Queenstown (buy food there; specific cafés not checked).

Day 9 · Sun 14 Mar · Return the car and fly

depart 07:45 · 9 km · Driving 13 min · Sunset 20:11

No sightseeing. Drive to Queenstown Airport, return the car, and check in for the 11:00 flight.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
07:45 depart	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside		
07:59	Queenstown Airport (car return)	9 km 13 min	Return the car by 08:45, two hours before the 11:00 international departure.

Tips

• Allow extra time at the Frankton roundabouts in the morning peak.

Bookings and tickets

Book by	Item	Date	Status	Ref	Terms / notes
2026-12-15	One-way rental car, Christchurch Airport 6 Mar about 15:45 to Queenstown Airport 14 Mar 08:45; one named driver; ask the one-way fee	2027-03-06	not booked		pick a free-cancellation rate · compare rental companies' own sites
2026-12-15	Novotel Christchurch Airport, 1 night, two beds	2027-03-06	not booked		https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2026-12-15	Peppers Bluewater Resort or Mantra Lake Tekapo, 1 night, two beds (Tekapo has few rooms; book first)	2027-03-10	not booked		https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2026-12-15	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside, 11 Mar and 13 Mar (two separate 1-night stays), two beds	2027-03-11	not booked		https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2027-01-15	Hokitika hotel/motel, 1 night, two beds	2027-03-07	not booked		
2027-01-15	Fox Glacier motel/lodge, 1 night, two beds	2027-03-08	not booked		
2027-01-15	Wanaka hotel/apartment, 1 night, two beds, free cancellation until 8 Mar	2027-03-09	not booked		
2027-01-15	Te Anau motel/hotel, 1 night, two beds	2027-03-12	not booked		
2027-02-15	Optional: Dark Sky Project stargazing tour, Lake Tekapo, evening of 10 Mar	2027-03-10	not booked		https://www.darkskyproject.co.nz/
	National Kiwi Centre entry (pay at the door)	2027-03-07	buy on site		https://www.thenationalkiwicentre.co.nz/
	White Horse Hill car park (Hooker Valley), pay by card at the machine	2027-03-10	buy on site		https://www.doc.govt.nz/parks-and-recreation/places-to-go/canterbury/places/aoraki-mount-cook-national-park/things-to-do/tracks/hooker-valley-track/

Hotels

Date	Hotel	Brand	Room	Cost	Status	Terms / notes
2027-03-06	Novotel Christchurch Airport	Accor	Two beds (twin or 2 queens)		not booked	choose a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2027-03-07	Hotel or motel in Hokitika (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)	—	Two beds (twin or 2 queens)		not booked	choose a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2027-03-08	Motel or lodge in Fox Glacier (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)	—	Two beds (twin or 2 queens)		not booked	choose a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2027-03-09	Hotel or apartment in Wanaka (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)	—	Two beds (twin or 2 queens)		not booked	must be free-cancellation until 8 Mar (Plan B) · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html

Date	Hotel	Brand	Room	Cost	Status	Terms / notes
2027-03-10	Peppers Bluewater Resort or Mantra Lake Tekapo	Accor	Two beds (twin or 2 queens)		not booked	choose a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2027-03-11	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside	Accor	Two beds (twin or 2 queens)		not booked	choose a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2027-03-12	Motel or hotel in Te Anau (to choose, two beds, up to NZ$300)	—	Two beds (twin or 2 queens)		not booked	choose a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html
2027-03-13	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside	Accor	Two beds (twin or 2 queens)		not booked	choose a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html

Open items

Your requirements

• [met] At most 500 km in any day

• [met] Never drive after dark

• [met] No boats or ferries at all (seasickness)

• [met] No ferries (same reason)

• [met] No beaches

• [met] No walks longer than about 2 hours

• [met] No sightseeing on 14 March, just return the car and fly

• [to confirm] Hotel budget up to NZ$300 per night

• [met] Car returned in time for the 11:00 flight from Queenstown on 14 March

Backup plans

• SH6 Haast Pass closed by slips or flooding on 9 Mar (decide by 2027-03-08): NZTA Journey Planner, SH6 Haast to Hawea, evening of 8 Mar and before leaving Fox · Plan B, checked with the same rules: 9 Mar leave Fox 08:00, back north via Franz Josef and Hokitika (fuel) and over Arthur's Pass (lunch) to Fable Terrace Downs, Windwhistle (Accor), arriving about 14:30, 354 km / 4 h 43. 10 Mar leave 07:45 via Geraldine to Lake Tekapo, Peters Lookout, Hooker Valley (about 12:45-14:30), Tasman Glacier View, then Tekapo by 17:25, 406 km / 5 h 32. From 11 Mar as planned. Cancel the Wanaka room; you miss Haast Pass and Wanaka. · https://www.journeys.nzta.govt.nz/

• Milford Road (SH94) closed on 12 Mar (heavy rain, rockfall) (decide by 2027-03-12): NZTA Journey Planner, SH94 Te Anau-Milford, before leaving Queenstown on 12 Mar · Plan C, checked with the same rules, hotels unchanged: 12 Mar leave Queenstown 08:00, Bennetts Bluff and Glenorchy, then via Kingston and Mossburn to Te Anau by about 13:45, 266 km. 13 Mar leave Te Anau 07:45, bird sanctuary, Milford Road to Milford Sound (about 11:15), back via Te Anau (fuel) to Queenstown by about 17:10, 413 km / 5 h 43. · https://www.journeys.nzta.govt.nz/

• SH73 Arthur's Pass closed on 7 Mar (decide by 2027-03-06): NZTA Journey Planner, SH73, evening of 6 Mar · Use SH7 Lewis Pass via Reefton and Greymouth to Hokitika instead (roughly 400 km; not routed or checked here); drop Castle Hill and Devils Punchbowl. · https://www.journeys.nzta.govt.nz/

• ASSUMED (not asked): a 2WD rental car (not a campervan) picked up at Christchurch Airport and returned at Queenstown Airport; the 11:00 flight is international, so the car goes back by 08:45; your first night is in Christchurch.

• DECIDE: a 5th Accor night? The planner's night-by-night search found it's only possible by adding a night at Fable Terrace Downs (Windwhistle, Accor MGallery) on 7 Mar. Day 2 would become a short 71 km day near Christchurch, and you'd lose the Hokitika and Fox nights for one Franz Josef night, with a 414 km / about 5 h 40 drive across Arthur's Pass on 8 Mar. Its price may be above NZ$300. Recommended: keep this plan (4 Accor nights, more sightseeing).

• DECIDE: optional helicopter glacier landing or heli-hike at Franz Josef on 8 Mar (weather-dependent; the free walk only reaches a viewpoint). Day 3 has room for about 3 hours of it.

• BOOK by 15 Dec 2026: the one-way rental car and the 4 Accor nights (Christchurch, Tekapo, Queenstown x2). Then by 15 Jan 2027: Hokitika, Fox Glacier, Wanaka (free-cancellation) and Te Anau.

• CONFIRM when booking: each room's price is NZ$300 or less with two beds; prices were not checked in this plan. Also each hotel's latest check-in time (all arrivals are before 18:00).

• UNVERIFIED: opening hours of Mt John summit road, Te Anau bird sanctuary and fuel in Haast/Te Anau; walk times for some short walks (all should be under 2 hours). Check on the day.

• Not covered: the Haast Pass, Arthur's Pass and Milford Road can close at short notice. Check NZTA Journey Planner the evening before, and use Plans B and C above.

Before you go

Checklist

• Licence: the driver's full Australian licence (in English) should be accepted in NZ for visits up to 12 months (not re-checked for this plan; confirm on the NZTA site). Carry the physical card. Only the named driver may drive.

• Rental: book a one-way Christchurch Airport to Queenstown Airport hire with free cancellation; ask the one-way fee, the excess and what's excluded (unsealed roads such as Skippers Road are often excluded). Confirm the desk opens for a about 15:45 pick-up on Sat 6 Mar and that early drop-off at 08:45 on Sun 14 Mar is fine.

• Car return: fuel policy (usually full-to-full; refuel in Queenstown on 13 Mar).

• Roads: NZTA Journey Planner (journeys.nzta.govt.nz) for SH73, SH6 Haast Pass and SH94 Milford Road the evening before each of those days. Drive on the left; many one-lane bridges on the West Coast (give way signs).

• Offline maps: download the West Coast, Haast Pass, Mount Cook and Milford Road areas; there is little or no mobile signal there.

• Hotels: book the 4 Accor nights first (ALL member rates), then the 4 others, all with free cancellation; Wanaka must be cancellable until 8 Mar for Plan B.

• Budget: check each room is NZ$300 or less for two beds; Queenstown and Tekapo in March may be above this, so compare the cheaper Accor brands there.

• Money: card-only parking at Aoraki/Mount Cook; carry a card that works for pay-at-pump fuel.

• Insurance: check that travel insurance covers the rental car excess and helicopter flights if you take one.

• Emergency: 111 in New Zealand. Save the rental company's breakdown number.

• Arrival: declare food, hiking boots and outdoor gear at Christchurch biosecurity; clean boots save time.

• Not done here: flights are booked; NZ entry requirements depend on passports, so check them yourselves.

Packing

• Walking shoes with grip for wet rainforest tracks (Devils Punchbowl, Blue Pools, The Chasm).

• Rain jacket: the West Coast and Fiordland are very wet even in late summer.

• Warm layer and hat for Arthur's Pass, Mount Cook and early starts (mornings can be cold).

• Insect repellent for sandflies on the West Coast, Haast and Milford Sound.

• Strong sunscreen and sunglasses: UV is high in March.

• Motion-sickness tablets for the winding passes (Arthur's Pass, Haast Pass, Milford Road), even without boats.

• Water bottles, snacks and a picnic lunch for the Milford Road day (buy in Te Anau).

• Phone car charger and mount; power adapter type I (same as Australia).

Sources

• https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/country/hotels-new-zealand-pnz.html (2026-11-09)

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• https://nominatim.openstreetmap.org / https://router.project-osrm.org (2026-11-09)

• NZTA driving in NZ on an overseas licence (not re-checked) (2026-11-09)

• general knowledge, not checked for 2027 (2026-11-09)

• assumption; check the rental car you get (2026-11-09)

• DOC track pages (not re-checked) (2026-11-09)